

The WINNING HAND



A shrinking, disunited opposition and strong allies like Sharad Pawar have helped Sonia Gandhi retain her shine

By Prabhu Chawla

It is as if even phonetics favours the politics of Sonia Gandhi. Is it a surge, or is it that she just soars, defying the gravitational pull of the treacherous cohabitation politics, or is it all about the persistence of shine? Despite the hat-trick in Maharashtra, face-saving in Haryana and the sweep in Arunachal Pradesh, Sonia doesn't rhyme with surge or soar, but she continues to shine in a polity littered with carbonised reputations of certain opposition grandees. The halo she acquired as the Madonna of India's Grand Old Party after the victory in the last two general elections is still intact. It is the victory of a master strategist and a leader who understands the limits of her spheres of influence and the value of political partnership. She has retained the momentum.

In Maharashtra, she could have played the fantasist and lost the election comfortably.

She could have played the "me-alone" diva and abandoned NCP leader Sharad Pawar, her decisive ally at the Centre. She could have taken lessons from the son and opted for a solo act. She didn't. She was the realist extraordinaire, fully realising the worth of give-and-take in a coalition. For she alone knew a simple truth: it's better to co-opt Pawar than make an enemy out of the Grand Maratha. Under her guidance, the Congress refused to follow the Bihar and Uttar Pradesh model and stayed with the tested, though not fully trustworthy, ally. It was the troika of Sonia, Pawar and Chief Minister Ashok Chavan that authored the convincing Maharashtra victory. The three had full faith in the power of the alliance. And look at how it worked.

Still the Congress didn't have to try so hard to retain the three states. Its lead, however tenuous it may be in Haryana, brings out a widening vacuum in Indian democracy: the overwhelming

